

From weakest to strongest: what can a mind be made of?

Step 1

Multiple realizability

The same mental state can be built from different physical parts.

Example: Your pain and my pain can use slightly different neurons and still both be pain.

clearest statement:
Fodor 1974

Step 2

Substrate flexibility

A mind could be built from some other material, but not necessarily from every material.

Example: Perhaps some non-living materials would work and others would not.

clearest statement:
Seth 2025

Step 3

Substrate independence

A mind can be built from any of a broad class of materials.

Example: Neurons or silicon chips: the material makes little difference.

clearest statement:
Bostrom 2003

Step 4

Organizational invariance

Copy how the parts act on each other, and you copy the mind, whatever the parts are made of.

Example: A silicon copy wired exactly like your brain would have your mind.

clearest statement:
Chalmers 1993/2011

each step claims more than the step before it

